ficker who gives the khaki warrior a run for her money. For director Tanuj Chopra, having two women centre stage was his way of delivering "a female version of" the iconic film *Heat*. "Men get to do it all the time," he says. "My dream was to have this face-off where women take the stage. It's like a dance between the two. One part of the show is social and rooted in the case; in the other, I get to show the cinematic side." If season two addressed fear, in three, Chopra taps into emotions.

Director *TANUJ CHOPRA* says it was his dream to have this face-off where women take the centre stage



For Chopra, it was also an opportunity to flex his filmmaking talent after taking over the reins from Richie Mehta, who delivered a banger of a season one and then chose to move on to other projects. Says Chopra, "Richie Mehta did such a good job of casting and creating the concept. It is easier for me to pick up what's working and take it to another place. I see it as a privilege." He knew that to succeed, he'd have to avoid falling into the trap of building a legacy. "You can't create trying to match something that's happened before; it's not fair to the performers who need to be in the moment."

Season three also sees a hardened Vartika who is transferred to Assam and returns to the capital to investigate a case with a nexus beyond India. For Shah, it's not just the growth of the character but also of her as a performer, the fact that she doesn't have to indulge in "*sheropanti*". "There was a need to prove her bravado in season one, but there's no need to do that here," she says.

"[In the first], I didn't know where it was going to go," says Shah of her career-defining role. "And, in the second, I was terrified—it's only when the reviews came out, I was like, 'We did it.' Here we are yet again. I'm so proud to be a part of the show and so possessive of her and who she is, but I am also terrified as f**k." ■

—Suhani Singh



▶ NOVEMBER 28

Tere Ishk Mein

Described by its makers as a spiritual successor to the 2013 superhit *Raanjhanaa,* the film marks Dhanush's return to Varanasi with a tale of toxic romance. The heroine is Kriti Sanon. Expect much screaming, crying and throwing things around, set to A.R. Rahman's tunes.



▼ NOVEMBER 14

KAANTHA



A star actor clashes with his mentor filmmaker, with an actress caught in the middle, in this 1950s Chennai-set Tamil drama. The cast is loaded: Dulquer Salmaan, Samuthirakani, Bhagyashri Borse and Rana Daggubati. Co-written by acclaimed novelist Tamizh Prabha.



▲ NOVEMBER 21

120 BAHADUR

Farhan Akhtar stars as Major Shaitan Singh, who led a small regiment defending their post against a 3,000-strong Chinese contingent during the 1962 war. The Major was awarded a posthumous Param Vir Chakra. The trailer promises realistic war sequences reminiscent of Akhtar-directed *Lakshya* (2004).

Compiled by Devarsi Ghosh